

Determinants of Financial Decision-Making Authority in Indian Households: Husband or Wife.

**Report submitted to
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ABSTRACT

Household financial decision-making dynamics are crucial for understanding family dynamics and economic empowerment. In many societies, including India, the decision-maker regarding household finances often holds significant power and influence. This study aims to explore the determinants of financial decision-making authority within Indian households, focusing on whether it is the wife or husband who primarily decides how money is allocated. Drawing upon data from the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) fifth round, conducted in 2019-2020, this research employs Multiple Linear Regression Models (MLRM) to analyze the factors influencing this decision-making process. Key variables considered include the gender and age of the household head, household demographics such as caste and religion, the number of wives in polygamous marriages, and factors indicating the relative influence of

spouses, such as decision-making authority over household purchases and visits to wife's family or relatives. Preliminary findings suggest that variables such as age and gender of the household head, caste and religion, and decision-making power over household purchases significantly impact whether the wife or husband takes the lead in financial decisions. Understanding these dynamics can inform policies aimed at promoting gender equality and financial inclusion within households, ultimately contributing to broader socio-economic development goals.

INTRODUCTION

The dynamics of financial decision-making within Indian households play a pivotal role in shaping family dynamics and socioeconomic outcomes. This study aims to explore the determinants of whether the wife or husband primarily holds authority

over financial decisions, utilizing data from the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) fifth round conducted between 2019-2020. Employing Multiple Linear Regression Models (MLRM), we delve into the intricate interplay of factors influencing this aspect of household functioning.

Key variables under scrutiny encompass a diverse range of socio-demographic characteristics and relational dynamics. These include the gender and age of the household head, socio-economic indicators such as caste and religion, the structural complexities of polygamous marriages, and indicators of spousal influence such as control over household purchases and decisions regarding family visits.

Preliminary findings suggest that a multitude of factors significantly shapes the locus of financial decision-making within households. Age and gender dynamics emerge as influential factors, alongside socio-cultural determinants like caste and religion. Additionally, the relative

power dynamics between spouses, as evidenced by control over household purchases and familial visits, play a crucial role in determining financial decision-making authority.

Understanding these intricate dynamics holds profound implications for policy interventions aimed at fostering gender equality and financial inclusion within Indian households. By addressing barriers to equitable decision-making and promoting avenues for greater spousal autonomy, policymakers can contribute to broader socio-economic development goals. Moreover, recognizing the nuanced interplay of socio-demographic factors in financial decision-making can inform targeted interventions tailored to the unique needs and circumstances of diverse households across India.

In sum, unraveling the determinants of financial decision-making authority within households is essential for advancing gender equality and promoting inclusive

economic development in India. Through rigorous analysis and informed policymaking, we can strive towards more equitable and empowered households, thereby fostering sustainable socio-economic progress.

Literature Review

Financial decision-making within households is a topic of considerable interest to scholars, policymakers, and practitioners alike, as it reflects broader societal dynamics related to gender roles, power structures, and economic well-being. Extensive research has been conducted globally, with a growing body of literature focusing on the Indian context.

Several studies have underscored the significance of gender dynamics in shaping financial decision-making within households. For instance, Kabeer (2005) highlights the unequal distribution of decision-making power between spouses in patriarchal societies, with women

often marginalized in economic matters.

Furthermore, research by Desai and Andrist (2010) and Govindasamy and Malhotra (1996) underscores the role of socio-economic factors, such as education and employment status, in determining women's bargaining power and influence over financial decisions. These studies suggest that women's empowerment and economic independence are key determinants of their involvement in household financial matters.

Moreover, studies focusing on household structure and dynamics offer valuable insights into the complexities of financial decision-making. For instance, Agarwal (1997) explores the implications of polygamous marriages on women's economic status and decision-making autonomy, highlighting the differential power dynamics within such households.

In addition to socio-economic factors, cultural and religious norms

also play a significant role in shaping financial decision-making patterns. Research by Desai and Jain (1994) and Sharma (2005) delves into the influence of caste and religious beliefs on intra-household resource allocation, revealing complex interactions between tradition, modernity, and gender dynamics.

Overall, the literature underscores the multidimensional nature of financial decision-making within Indian households, influenced by a complex interplay of socio-economic, cultural, and relational factors. By synthesizing insights from existing research, this study seeks to contribute to a deeper understanding of these dynamics and inform policy interventions aimed at promoting gender equality and financial inclusion within households.

DATA & VARIABLE

The data is collected from the NFHS site - <https://rchiips.org/nfhs/> , it requires a procedure to follow

- 1) Fill out a user registration form (which includes your personal details)
- 2) Create a project which includes the model specification variables and some brief explanation about your research paper and then compose a mail then wait for their approval.
- 3) Once your mail got approved then you can access your data set.

Variable

In this model we include 1 dependent variable and 7 independent variable, the following are the variables -

- **DEPENDENT VARIABLE**
 - 1) md (who should have the greater say when deciding what to do with the money either wife or husband)
- **INDEPENDENT VARIABLE**

- 1) vis (who should have the greater say when deciding visit to wife family and relatives)
- 2) dhp (who should have the greater say when making purchases for daily household needs)
- 3) mhp (who should have the greater say when making major household purchases)
- 4) numw (number of wives/partners)
- 5) Head (gender & age of head)
- 6) relg (Religion)
- 7) caste (belong to a scheduled caste/tribe/other backward class)

Descriptive statistics

Note : label value for husband =1, wife = 2, both equal = 3, don't know = 8.

- 1) md (who should have the greater say when deciding what to do with the money either wife or husband)

who should have the greater say when deciding what to do with the money the wife	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
husband	14,673	13.82	13.82
wife	18,693	17.60	31.42
both equally	70,283	66.18	97.60
don't know / depends	2,551	2.40	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

2) vis (who should have the greater say when deciding visit to wife family and relatives)

who should have the greater say when deciding visits to the wife's family or rel	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
husband	21,383	20.13	20.13
wife	9,911	9.33	29.47
both equally	72,535	68.30	97.77
don't know / depends	2,371	2.23	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

3) dhp (who should have the greater say when making purchases for daily household needs)

who should have the greater say when making purchases for daily household needs	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
husband	21,012	19.79	19.79
wife	25,322	23.84	43.63
both equally	57,685	54.32	97.95
don't know / depends	2,181	2.05	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

4) mhp (who should have the greater say when making major household purchases)

who should have the greater say when making major household purchases	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
husband	28,907	27.22	27.22
wife	7,939	7.48	34.69
both equally	67,006	63.09	97.79
don't know / depends	2,348	2.21	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

5) numw (number of wives/partners)

number of wives/partners	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
no wives/partners	39,549	37.24	37.24
1	66,326	62.45	99.69
2	315	0.30	99.99
3	8	0.01	100.00
4	1	0.00	100.00
5	1	0.00	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

6)Head (gender & age of head)

= [gender * age]

Note : gender label value => 1

= male and 2 for female.

gender & age of head	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
15	2	0.00	0.00
16	15	0.01	0.02
17	25	0.02	0.04
18	107	0.10	0.14
19	95	0.09	0.23
20	211	0.20	0.43
21	253	0.24	0.67
22	458	0.43	1.10
23	496	0.47	1.56
24	576	0.54	2.11
25	989	0.93	3.04
26	921	0.87	3.91
27	958	0.90	4.81
28	1,379	1.30	6.11
29	1,005	0.95	7.05
30	2,244	2.11	9.17
31	1,018	0.96	10.12
32	1,903	1.79	11.92
33	1,221	1.15	13.07
34	1,430	1.35	14.41
35	3,369	3.17	17.58

142	54	0.05	99.21
144	87	0.08	99.29
146	42	0.04	99.33
148	53	0.05	99.38
150	216	0.20	99.59
152	37	0.03	99.62
154	15	0.01	99.64
156	67	0.06	99.70
158	22	0.02	99.72
160	120	0.11	99.83
162	12	0.01	99.84
164	29	0.03	99.87
166	10	0.01	99.88
168	16	0.02	99.90
170	60	0.06	99.95
172	7	0.01	99.96
174	4	0.00	99.96
176	5	0.00	99.97
178	2	0.00	99.97
180	18	0.02	99.99
186	1	0.00	99.99
188	4	0.00	99.99
190	9	0.01	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

more....

7)relg (Religion)

religion	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
hindu	82,097	77.30	77.30
muslim	11,308	10.65	87.95
christian	7,578	7.14	95.09
sikh	2,362	2.22	97.31
buddhist/neo-buddhist	1,571	1.48	98.79
jain	169	0.16	98.95
jewish	3	0.00	98.95
no religion	60	0.06	99.01
other	1,052	0.99	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

8) caste (belong to a scheduled caste/tribe/other backward class)

belong to a scheduled caste/tribe/ot her backward class	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
schedule caste	19,875	18.71	18.71
schedule tribe	20,026	18.86	37.57
obc	43,434	40.90	78.47
none of them	22,564	21.25	99.72
don't know	301	0.28	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

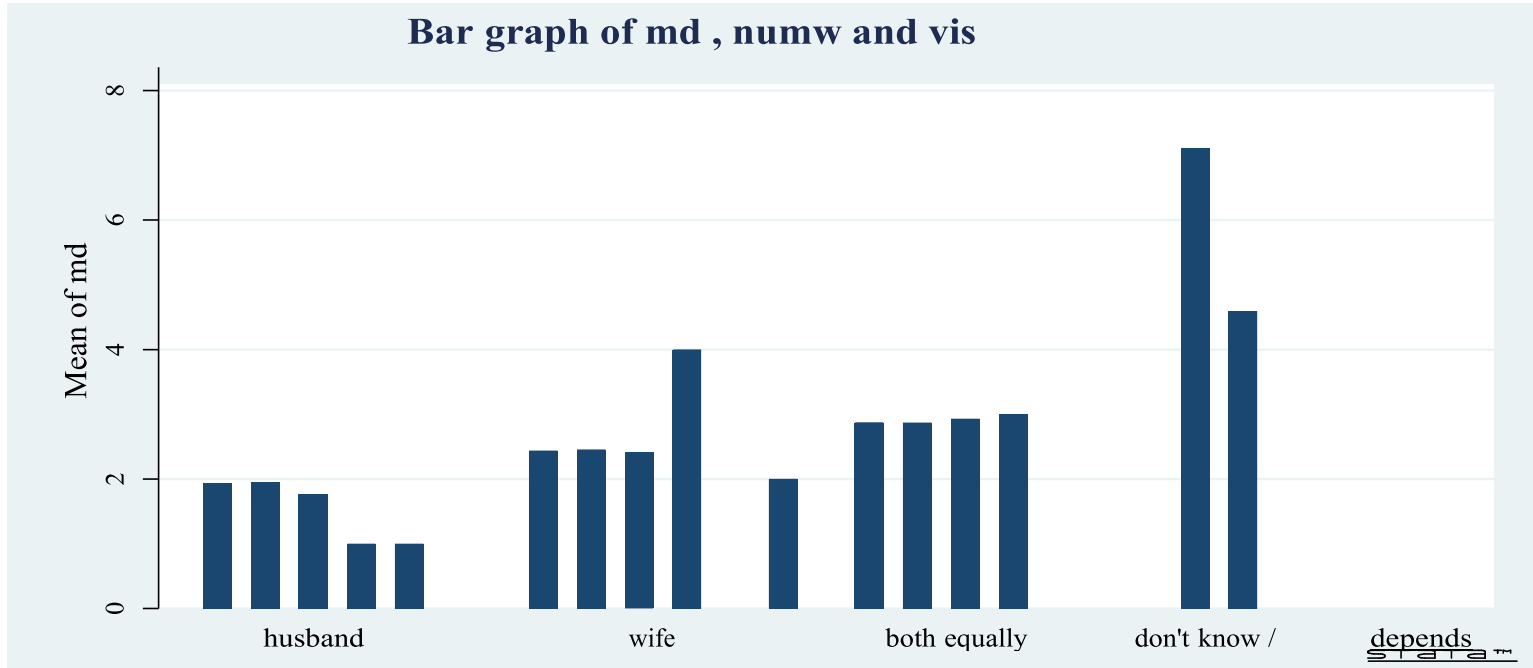
religion	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
1	82,097	77.30	77.30
2	11,308	10.65	87.95
3	7,578	7.14	95.09
4	2,362	2.22	97.31
5	1,571	1.48	98.79
6	169	0.16	98.95
7	3	0.00	98.95
9	60	0.06	99.01
96	1,052	0.99	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

belong to a scheduled caste/tribe /other backward class	Freq.	Percent	Cum.
1	19,875	18.71	18.71
2	20,026	18.86	37.57
3	43,434	40.90	78.47
4	22,564	21.25	99.72
8	301	0.28	100.00
Total	106,200	100.00	

Summary

This summary provides key statistics for each variable, including the mean, standard deviation, minimum, and maximum values.

Variable	n	Mean	S.D.	----- Quantiles -----				
				Min	.25	Mdn	.75	Max
md	106200	2.67	1.10	1.00	2.00	3.00	3.00	8.00
vis	106200	2.62	1.14	1.00	2.00	3.00	3.00	8.00
dhp	106200	2.47	1.12	1.00	2.00	3.00	3.00	8.00
mhp	106200	2.49	1.21	1.00	1.00	3.00	3.00	8.00
numw	106200	0.63	0.49	0.00	0.00	1.00	1.00	5.00
Head	106200	52.96	22.84	15.00	40.00	48.00	60.00	190.00
relg	106200	2.33	9.41	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	96.00
caste	106200	2.66	1.05	1.00	2.00	3.00	3.00	8.00



Graphic Analysis

1) On the y-axis (MD): Represents responses regarding who should have the greater say when deciding what to do with the money. The categories include husband (1), wife (2), both equal (3), and don't know (8).

On the x-axis (numw): Represents the number of wives, ranging from 1 to 5.

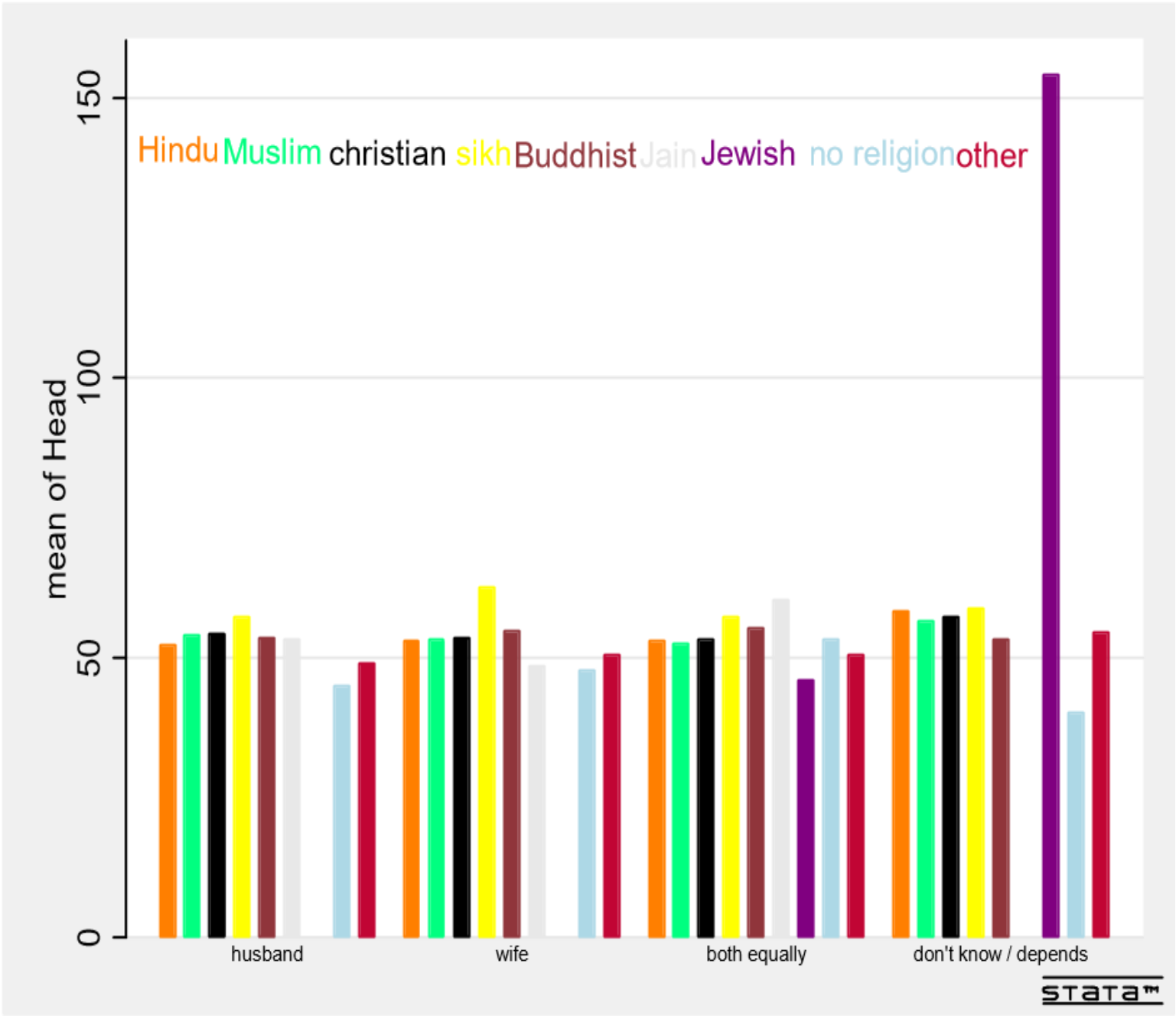
On the x-axis (vis): Represents responses regarding who should have the greater say when deciding visits to the wife's family and relatives. The categories are husband (1), wife (2), both equal (3), and don't know (8).

- When respondents believe the husband should have the greater say in family visits, the decision-making authority for financial matters tends to align with the husband, regardless of the number of wives
- Conversely, if respondents favor the wife's authority in family visit decisions,

the decision-making authority for financial matters typically lies with the wife, except when there are four wives, where the decision might fluctuate and be considered both equally.

- When respondents perceive decision-making authority for family visits to be shared equally (both equally), the decision-making authority for financial matters also tends to be shared equally, irrespective of the number of wives.
- If respondents are uncertain or respond "don't know" regarding family visit decision-making, the decision-making authority for financial matters tends to be shared equally, with most respondents having one to two wives among those who answered "don't know."

These findings highlight the interconnectedness of decision-making dynamics within marriages and underscore the importance of understanding and addressing power dynamics and equity in marital relationships.



2)

a. Y-axis (Mean of Gender & Age of Household Head):

- The y-axis represents the average or mean value of two variables: gender and age of household heads. This could mean the average age and gender distribution of household heads in your dataset.

b. X-axis (Religion of Head and Decision-Making for major Purchases):

- The x-axis is divided into categories based on the religion of the household head and who should have the greater say when making major household purchases. Each category could represent a different combination of these two variables.

c. Bar Heights:

- Each bar on the graph represents a combination of a specific religion of the household head and their preference regarding decision-making for major household purchases.

- The height of each bar indicates the mean value of gender and age for that particular category. A taller bar would suggest a higher average value for gender and age within that group.

d. Interpretation:

- You can interpret this graph by comparing the heights of the bars across different categories.

- For example, if the answer for decision-Making for Purchases is husband and the religion is for the same is Hindu, then head can be define as 25 year old male or 50 year old female.

Methodology:

This study employs a quantitative and qualitative research approach to investigate the determinants of financial decision-making authority within Indian households. The analysis utilizes data from the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) fifth round, conducted between 2019-2020, which provides comprehensive information on household demographics, socio-economic indicators, and relational dynamics.

The primary analytical technique utilized in this study is Multiple Linear Regression Models (MLRM). MLRM allows for the examination of the relationship between multiple independent variables and a continuous dependent variable, in this case, the determination of whether the wife or husband predominantly holds authority over financial decisions within households.

Key variables of interest include:

1. Gender and age of the household head: These variables capture the demographic characteristics of the individual primarily responsible for household decision-making.
2. Socio-economic indicators: Variables such as caste, religion, and educational attainment serve as proxies for socio-economic status, which may influence decision-making dynamics within households.
3. Household structure: Factors such as the number of wives in polygamous marriages provide insights into the structural complexities of household dynamics and their implications for financial decision-making.
4. Spousal influence indicators: Variables indicating control over household purchases and decisions regarding family visits are included to assess the relative power dynamics between spouses and their impact on financial decision-making.

The analysis proceeds in several steps:

1. Data preparation: The NFHS 5 dataset (men) is cleaned and organized to ensure consistency and accuracy in the variables of interest.

2. Descriptive analysis: Descriptive statistics are computed to provide an overview of the distribution of key variables and their relationship with financial decision-making authority.

3. Multiple Linear Regression analysis: MLRM is employed to examine the relationship between independent variables and the dependent variable, controlling for potential confounding factors. The significance and magnitude of coefficients are assessed to identify the key determinants of financial decision-making within households.

4. Stata has been used for computing the data value and clearing the unwanted data, it has been helpful for making graphs.

5. The Ordinary Least Square (OLS) technique is applied for regression. Regression is one of the tools used for

data analysis. The focus is on analysing and characterizing the causal and functional relationship between variables.

6. We must define our MLRM as follows:

$$md = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \times vis + \beta_2 \times dhp + \beta_3 \times mhp + \beta_4 \times numw + \beta_5 \times Head + \beta_6 \times relg + \beta_7 \times caste + \epsilon$$

Where:

mdmd is the dependent variable (who should have the greater say when deciding what to do with the money).

vis, dhp, mhp, numw, Head, relg, caste are the independent variables (who should have the greater say when deciding visit to wife family and relatives, who should have the greater say when making purchases for daily household needs, who should have the greater say when making major household purchases, number of wives/partners, gender & age of head, religion, and caste, respectively).

$\beta_0, \beta_1, \beta_2, \beta_3, \beta_4, \beta_5, \beta_6, \beta_7$ are the coefficients of the independent variables.

ϵ represents the error term.

To analyze the factors influencing the decision-making authority regarding

(who should have the greater say when deciding what to do with the money) (md), we conducted a multiple linear regression analysis. We verified the key components of the regression equation, including:

- Goodness of Fit (R-squared):

The R-squared value indicates the proportion of variance in the dependent variable (md) explained by the independent variables. A value close to 1 suggests a good fit, signifying that the independent variables significantly contribute to understanding the variation in md.

Statistical Significance of Coefficients:

Each coefficient (β) represents the effect of an independent variable on md. A statistically significant coefficient ($p < 0.05$) indicates that the corresponding independent variable has a significant impact on md. Conversely, an insignificant coefficient suggests that the variable may not significantly influence md.

Overall Significance (F-test):

The F-test assesses the overall significance of the regression model. A significant F-test ($p < 0.05$) indicates that at least one independent variable in the model significantly affects md.

Heteroskedasticity Test (Breusch-Pagan-Godfrey):

Heteroskedasticity can affect the efficiency of estimators and standard errors. The Breusch-Pagan-Godfrey test detects heteroskedasticity in the residuals of the regression model. If present, heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are applied to correct standard errors.

Multicollinearity Test (Variance Inflation Factors - VIF):

Multicollinearity arises when independent variables are highly correlated, leading to imprecise estimates. The Variance Inflation Factors (VIF) test evaluates the severity of multicollinearity. VIF values greater than 10 indicate serious multicollinearity, while values between 3 and 10 suggest moderate multicollinearity. VIF values below 3 indicate an absence of multicollinearity.

By conducting these diagnostic tests, we ensure the reliability and validity of the multiple linear regression model used to analyze the factors influencing decision-making authority regarding what to do with the money.

By rigorously analyzing these factors, this study aims to provide valuable insights into the determinants of financial decision-making authority within Indian households and contribute to the existing literature on gender dynamics, socio-economic factors, and household structure.

Result and discussion

Table 1: OLS estimates of md

Source	SS	df	MS	Number of obs = 106200		
Model	64727.828	7	9246.83257	F(7,106192) =15174.61		
Residual	64709.3787106192		.609362086	Prob > F = 0.0000		
Total	129437.207106199	1.21881757		R-squared = 0.5001		
				Adj R-squared = 0.5000		
				Root MSE = .78062		

md	Coef.	Std. Err.	t	P> t	[95% Conf. Interval]	
vis	.4144137	.0028898	143.40	0.000	.4087496	.4200777
dhp	.2242461	.0036523	61.40	0.000	.2170876	.2314045
mhp	.1179988	.0031729	37.19	0.000	.1117799	.1242177
caste	-.0067649	.002282	-2.96	0.003	-.0112376	-.0022921
relg	.0005742	.000255	2.25	0.024	.0000744	.0010739
numw	-.0228008	.0050262	-4.54	0.000	-.0326522	-.0129495
Head	-.0001439	.0001071	-1.34	0.179	-.0003538	.000066
_cons	.7749565	.0112977	68.59	0.000	.7528131	.7970999

Each estimated coefficients in the above table represents the partial effect of change in its associated explanatory variable on the dependent variable

- explore the determinants of decision-making regarding the The multiple linear regression model was conducted to allocation of household finances, with the dependent

variable being "who should have the greater say when deciding what to do with the money" (md). The independent variables considered in the analysis are:

- vis, dhp, mhp: Positive coefficients would imply that as the preference for decision-making authority shifts towards a specific party regarding visits, daily household needs, or major purchases, the likelihood of them having a greater say in financial decisions increases.
- numw: A negative coefficient would suggest that as the number of wives/partners increases, the likelihood of each individual having a greater say in financial decisions decreases.
- Head: The coefficient's significance indicates whether the gender and age of the household head influence decision-making regarding finances.
- relg, caste: Coefficients' signs and significance reveal the

influence of religion and caste on financial decision-making authority within households

Effect of Independent Variables:

- For every one-unit increase in vis (who should have the greater say when deciding visits to wife family and relatives), there is a 0.4144137 increase in the predicted value of md.
- Similarly, for every one-unit increase in dhp (who should have the greater say when making purchases for daily household needs), there is a 0.2242461 increase in the predicted value of md.
- For every one-unit increase in mhp (who should have the greater say when making major household purchases), there is a 0.1179988 increase in the predicted value of md.
- caste has a negative coefficient, indicating that belonging to a scheduled caste/tribe/other backward class is associated with a decrease in the predicted value of md , there is a

0.0067649 decrease in the predicted value of md for every one-unit increase in caste.

- relg (religion) also has a positive coefficient, indicating that certain religious affiliations may influence preferences regarding decision-making in financial matters , there is a 0.0005742 increase in the predicted value of md for every one-unit increase in relg .
- numw (number of wives/partners) has a negative coefficient, suggesting that as the number of wives increases, the predicted value of md decreases , there is a 0.0228008 decrease in the predicted value of md for every one-unit increase in caste.
- Head (gender & age of head) has a negative coefficient, suggesting that as the number of wives increases, the predicted value of md decreases, there is a 0.0001439 decrease in the predicted value

of md for every one-unit increase in caste

Model Fit:

The model explains approximately 50.01% of the variance in the dependent variable md, as indicated by the R-squared value of 0.5001.

The F-statistic of 15174.61 with a p-value of 0.0000 suggests that the overall model is statistically significant.

The results suggest that various factors such as preferences regarding family visits, household purchase decisions, caste, religion, and the number of wives/partners significantly influence who should have the greater say in financial matters within households.

Table – 2 Multicollinearity test

Variable	VIF
dhp	2.93
mhp	2.56
vis	1.91
numw	1.05
Head	1.04
caste	1.01
relg	1.00
Mean VIF	1.64

The presence of multicollinearity in the data provides the biased estimates. To detect the multicollinearity Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) test is performed. It is shown in the table 2; the value of centred VIF for all the explanatory variables is less than 3. We conclude that there is no evidence of

multicollinearity in the context of our estimated regression model.

Heteroskedasticity test is compulsory in the context of cross-section analysis. In this study to perform the test of heteroskedasticity in the context of our estimated model, we have applied the Breusch-Pagan-Godfrey test

Breusch-Pagan / Cook-Weisberg test for heteroskedasticity

Ho: Constant variance

Variables: fitted values of md

chi2(1) = 2385.37

Prob > chi2 = 0.0000

The Breusch-Pagan / Cook-Weisberg test was conducted to assess the presence of heteroskedasticity in the regression model. The null hypothesis (Ho) assumes constant variance, meaning that the error terms are homoskedastic. Test Outcome: Test Statistic (chi2): The chi-square test

statistic is calculated as 2385.37. Probability (Prob > chi2): The p-value associated with the chi-square test statistic is found to be 0.0000.

Interpretation: With a p-value less than the significance level (typically 0.05), we reject the null hypothesis of constant variance. The low p-value indicates that there is strong evidence against the assumption of constant variance, suggesting the presence of heteroskedasticity in the regression mode , the results of the Breusch-Pagan / Cook-Weisberg test provide evidence that heteroskedasticity exists in the regression mode

Therefore, adjustments or robust standard errors may be necessary to address this issue and ensure the reliability of the regression results.

Linear regression

Number of obs = 106200
F(7,106192) = 4428.00
Prob > F = 0.0000
R-squared = 0.5001
Root MSE = .78062

md	Robust					
	Coef.	Std. Err.	t	P> t	[95% Conf. Interval]	
vis	.4144137	.006254	66.26	0.000	.402156	.4266714
dhp	.2242461	.0067771	33.09	0.000	.2109631	.2375291
mhp	.1179988	.0052886	22.31	0.000	.1076331	.1283644
caste	-.0067649	.0022738	-2.98	0.003	-.0112216	-.0023082
relg	.0005742	.000275	2.09	0.037	.0000351	.0011132
numw	-.0228008	.0049479	-4.61	0.000	-.0324987	-.0131029
Head	-.0001439	.000105	-1.37	0.171	-.0003497	.0000619
_cons	.7749565	.0142921	54.22	0.000	.7469442	.8029687

Computing robust standard errors using the Huber-White sandwich estimator, which is robust to heteroskedasticity. It should provide you with reliable standard errors even in the presence of heteroskedasticity.

Now we can conclude that the estimated model is unbiased on the basis of these tests of hetroskedasticity and multicollinearity

CONCLUSION

The results indicate that as the preference for decision-making authority regarding visits to wife family and relatives, daily household needs, and major household purchases increases, the likelihood of having a greater say in financial decisions also increases. Conversely, belonging to a scheduled caste/tribe/other backward class is associated with a decrease in financial decision-making authority.

Religious affiliation also influences preferences regarding financial decision-making, with certain religious groups exhibiting a greater inclination towards having a say in financial matters. Moreover, households with fewer wives/partners and those with a female or younger household head tend to have a greater say in financial decisions.

Overall, the model explains approximately 50.01% of the

variance in financial decision-making, suggesting that the included variables provide a significant understanding of the determinants of financial decision-making within households. These findings contribute to a deeper understanding of intra-household dynamics and have implications for policy and intervention strategies aimed at empowering individuals in financial decision-making processes.

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